Cup1 Phase 2 – Supplier Sourcing Pack

Custom-printed paper cups & food packaging for the USA and Canada

5 November 2026

Summary

Source US and Canadian orders from **Sowinpak's Vietnam plant**, not its China plant. Tariffs make this the single biggest cost decision in Phase 2.

- **USA:** paper cups (HTS 4823.69.00) made in China pay about **37.5%** extra duty (25% Section 301 + 12.5% base tariff). Made in Vietnam they pay about **12.5%**.
- **Canada:** CBSA is investigating Chinese paperboard cups and containers for dumping and subsidies. Estimated margins are 75.8% + 49.6%, and a preliminary decision is due by **16 Nov 2026**. Do not quote China-made cups to Canadian clients until it is resolved.
- **Lead product:** 12oz double-wall custom-printed hot cup. The full cups, bowls and boxes range follows once the first quotes are in.
- **Primary supplier:** Zhejiang Sowinpak, which has China and Vietnam plants plus BRC, BPI and FSC certificates. **Price benchmark:** Haining Xinhua. **Small-order option:** Wenzhou Liping (MOQ 5,000).
- **Early economics:** at a placeholder $0.06 FOB, an order of 100,000 cups lands in the US at about $0.11/cup (Vietnam) to $0.12/cup (China). A 35% gross margin gives a client price of $0.17–0.19/cup, against about $0.38/cup from US online sellers. The full model is in *Cup1_Phase2_Sourcing_Model.xlsx*.

No supplier has been contacted yet. The RFQ and sample request below are ready to send.

Landed cost snapshot (100,000 cups, placeholder FOB $0.06/cup)

Route	Total duty rate	Landed cost / cup	Client price / cup (35% GM)	Net profit / order
China → USA	37.5%	$0.125	$0.192	$6,014
Vietnam → USA	12.5%	$0.110	$0.169	$5,206
Vietnam → Canada	0% (MFN, to verify)	$0.102	$0.157	$4,780
China → Canada (AD/CVD risk)	125.4% (estimate)	$0.177	$0.272	not competitive

Freight, broker and inland costs are assumptions until forwarder quotes arrive. All inputs can be changed in the workbook.

Supplier shortlist

Sowinpak scores highest (4.6 of 5). It is the only supplier on the list with both North-America-grade certificates and a non-China plant. Figures come from each Alibaba storefront, viewed 5 Nov 2026.

Supplier	Location	Certificates shown	Track record	Listed price (USD/pc)	MOQ	Score /5
Zhejiang Sowinpak	Wenzhou CN + Vietnam plant	ISO 9001/14001/22000, HACCP, BRC, BRCGS Packaging,	2 yrs on Alibaba, 5.0 rating, 100% on-time, 0% disputes	0.0246–0.182	30,000	4.6

Supplier	Location	Certificates shown	Track record	Listed price (USD/pc)	MOQ	Score /5
		FSC, PEFC, BPI, DIN CERTCO				
Haining Xinhua Paper Cup	Haining, CN	None listed	6 yrs, 53 orders (US$850k+), 100% on-time	0.02–0.04	30,000	2.9
Wenzhou Liping	Wenzhou, CN	ISO 9001/14001/45001, FSC, LFGB	9 yrs, 4.8 rating, 66.7% on-time	0.05–0.08	5,000	2.6
Dongyuan Haoyuan Paper Cup	Dongyang, CN	None listed	20 yrs, only 3 online orders	0.042–0.092	100,000	2.3
Thuan Loi (Long An)	Long An, VN	None listed for paper cups	11 yrs, no performance data	$20/box (qty unclear)	100 boxes	2.2

There is a gap: no strong, verified Vietnamese paper-cup factory exists beyond Sowinpak's own plant. Finding a second Vietnam source is an open task.

RFQ message

Send this one message to all five suppliers through Alibaba "Contact supplier". The same spec makes the quotes directly comparable.

Subject: RFQ – Custom printed 12oz double-wall paper cups for US & Canada – Cup1

Hello [Name],

I am [Your name] from Cup1, a sourcing and packaging company supplying cafés, restaurants and food-service distributors in the USA and Canada. We are selecting a long-term paper cup manufacturer and would like your best quotation for:

- **Product:** 12oz (approx. 360–400ml) double-wall hot paper cup, 90mm rim, food-grade PE coating (please also quote aqueous / plastic-free coating if available)
- **Printing:** custom logo, 1–2 colours (also quote full-colour CMYK)
- **Quantities:** 30,000 / 50,000 / 100,000 pcs
- **Lids:** matching 90mm lids (PS and PLA/fibre options) priced separately

Please include:

1. Unit price at each quantity, and the paper GSM used
2. Printing plate / setup charge
3. Sample cost and sample lead time (blank and printed)
4. Production lead time after artwork approval
5. Carton packing: pcs per carton, carton size (cm) and gross weight
6. Price terms: FOB [port] and CIF Los Angeles
7. Payment terms, and whether you accept Alibaba Trade Assurance
8. **Production location: can this order be produced in Vietnam, with a Vietnamese certificate of origin?** (Sowinpak only)
9. Copies of: FDA food-contact test report, PFAS-free test report, FSC certificate, and BPI / BRC certificates if held

We expect regular repeat orders as our client base grows. We look forward to your reply.

Best regards, [Your name] · Cup1 · [email] · [WhatsApp]

Supplier verification checklist

A supplier is cleared for US or Canadian client orders only when every item below is ticked.

Legal & documents

- ☐ Business licence matches the Alibaba company name and the factory address
- ☐ Certificates checked on the issuer's website (BRC directory, BPI product catalog, FSC info.fsc.org), not just a PDF
- ☐ FDA food-contact test report (21 CFR 176.170 for PE-coated paperboard), from an accredited lab, less than 12 months old
- ☐ PFAS-free test report (total organic fluorine), needed for states such as CA, NY, WA, MN, CO
- ☐ For a Vietnam-made order: certificate of origin and the Vietnam factory address. Confirm the cups are formed and printed there, not transshipped from China

Capability

- ☐ Video call or live video tour of the cup-forming and printing lines
- ☐ Printed sample matches our Pantone colours and passes a leak test (hot water, 30 min)
- ☐ Double-wall cup stays comfortable to hold with 90°C water
- ☐ Lid fits snugly with no leaks when the cup is tipped

Commercial

- ☐ Order placed through Alibaba Trade Assurance (payment protection)
- ☐ Third-party pre-shipment inspection agreed (e.g. SGS, QIMA, V-Trust, about $300) before the balance is paid
- ☐ Written lead time and a late-delivery penalty clause

Sample request

Order samples only from the top two RFQ responses, ideally Sowinpak (Vietnam plant) and the cheapest China quote.

> Hello [Name],
>
> Thank you for your quotation. Before placing our first order we would like samples:
>
> 1. Blank 12oz double-wall cups – 20 pcs, with matching lids
> 2. Your existing printed samples in 8oz, 12oz and 16oz – 5 pcs each
> 3. One printed sample with our logo (artwork attached), if a digital or proof print is possible
>
> Please ship by express courier to: [address]. Let us know the sample and courier cost and we will pay via Alibaba. Please also include copies of your FDA and PFAS test reports with the shipment.
>
> Best regards, [Your name] · Cup1

The sample photos also feed Phase 3 (branding) and Phase 4 (the website).

Target clients (US & Canada)

Start with multi-location independent café groups (3–30 stores). One order from one of them reaches the 30,000-cup MOQ, and they pay US distributors $0.13–0.38 per printed cup.

Segment	Typical order	Where to find them	Cup1 pitch
Independent café groups (3–30 stores)	30k–100k cups per quarter	Google Maps, Instagram, LinkedIn	Own branded cups at distributor-beating prices, with

Segment	Typical order	Where to find them	Cup1 pitch
			FDA and PFAS-free paperwork
Bubble tea & smoothie chains	50k+ cups, cold cups too	Franchise directories, Yelp	Full branded range: cups, lids, carriers, bowls
Bakery-cafés & dessert / frozen-yogurt shops	30k ice-cream cups + boxes	Instagram, local directories	Ice-cream cups (outside Canada's anti-dumping scope) + window boxes
Regional packaging distributors	200k+ (full containers)	ThomasNet, trade shows (e.g. PACK EXPO)	Factory-direct private label from Vietnam, lower duty than China
Corporate / event catering & universities	30k–50k	Procurement portals, LinkedIn	Compostable (BPI) branded cups for sustainability targets

The named prospect list (20–30 businesses) is the first task of Phase 5, once sample quality is confirmed.

Next steps

#	Action	Target date
1	Send the RFQ to all 5 suppliers	7 Nov 2026
2	Ask Sowinpak directly: can 12oz double-wall cups be made at the Vietnam plant, and at what price?	7 Nov 2026
3	Check CBSA's preliminary decision on Chinese paper cups; update the Canada column of the cost model	17 Nov 2026
4	Get one freight forwarder quote (LCL, Ningbo/Haiphong → Los Angeles and Vancouver)	14 Nov 2026
5	Ask a licensed US customs broker to confirm the 37.5% / 12.5% duty rates	14 Nov 2026
6	Order samples from the top 2 suppliers	20 Nov 2026
7	Search for a second Vietnam paper-cup factory	Ongoing

Sources

- Sowinpak Alibaba profile – https://sowinpak88.en.alibaba.com/company_profile.html
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- US Vietnam tariff 2026 – https://www.tariffstool.com/guides/importing-from-vietnam-to-us
- Paper hot cups from China, duty – https://tariffs.wove.com/us/tariff/4823.69.00.20/paper-hot-coffee-cups/from/CN
- CBSA notice, paperboard cups & containers (PCC 2026) – https://www.cbsa-asfc.gc.ca/sima-lmsi/i-e/pcc2026/pcc2026-ni-eng.html
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- RestaurantSupplyDrop 30k custom cups – https://www.restaurantsupplydrop.com/products/custom-paper-coffee-cups-wholesale
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